

Week 1 Lit Example Reader

MACBETH: PROPHECY, POSSIBILITY, AND PROOF

Purpose: This reader gives two short Macbeth passages for applying Week 1's logic habit: identify the conclusion, stated reason, hidden assumption, and whether the conclusion follows. Read the passages as first-year college students: slowly, precisely, and with attention to what has actually been proved.

What to watch for: Macbeth does not simply hear information. He begins to reason from it. The question is not whether the witches are interesting, frightening, or dramatically powerful. The logical question is: *What follows from what?*

Before the Passages: The Week 1 Logic Tool

Whately's opening lesson is modest but demanding. Logic does not tell Macbeth what he wants, what he fears, or what the future will contain. It asks whether a conclusion has been earned by the reasons offered. For each passage, keep four questions separate:

1. **Conclusion:** What claim is the speaker moving toward?
2. **Stated reason:** What evidence or support is actually given?
3. **Hidden assumption:** What unstated idea must be true for the reason to prove the conclusion?
4. **Follow-test:** Does the conclusion really follow, or does the speaker move too quickly?

Do not reduce the scene to a moral slogan. Macbeth's thought is complicated. A careful reader should be able to say both what tempts him and what the logic does or does not prove.

Passage 1: Act 1, Scene 3 — After the Witches Speak

Context: The witches have greeted Macbeth with titles: Thane of Glamis, Thane of Cawdor, and future king. Soon afterward, messengers confirm that Macbeth has indeed been named Thane of Cawdor. Macbeth now has one confirmed prediction and one much larger unfulfilled prediction.

Banquo. But 'tis strange:

And oftentimes, to win us to our harm,
The instruments of darkness tell us truths,
Win us with honest trifles, to betray's
In deepest consequence.

Macbeth. Two truths are told,
As happy prologues to the swelling act
Of the imperial theme. . . .
This supernatural soliciting
Cannot be ill, cannot be good: if ill,

Why hath it given me earnest of success,
Commencing in a truth? I am Thane of Cawdor:
If good, why do I yield to that suggestion
Whose horrid image doth unfix my hair
And make my seated heart knock at my ribs,
Against the use of nature? Present fears
Are less than horrible imaginings.
My thought, whose murder yet is but fantastical,
Shakes so my single state of man
That function is smother'd in surmise,
And nothing is but what is not.
Macbeth. If chance will have me king, why, chance may crown me,
Without my stir.

Reader Notes

Banquo and Macbeth respond differently to the same facts. Banquo warns that a true statement can still be dangerous if it leads a person toward a false inference. Macbeth notices that part of the prophecy has come true, but he also notices that his own imagination is moving toward murder. The passage invites a logical distinction between *a prediction being partly confirmed* and *a murder becoming justified, necessary, or excused*.

Reading task: Mark where Macbeth names evidence, where he moves into possibility, and where his imagination begins adding what the witches did not directly command.

Passage 2: Act 1, Scene 7 — Macbeth Tests the Murder

Context: Duncan is Macbeth's king, kinsman, and guest. Macbeth is considering whether to murder him. In this soliloquy, Macbeth briefly becomes his own critic. He names several reasons not to act, and then he names the motive pushing him forward.

Macbeth. If it were done when 'tis done, then 'twere well
It were done quickly: if the assassination
Could trammel up the consequence, and catch
With his surcease success; that but this blow
Might be the be-all and the end-all here,
But here, upon this bank and shoal of time,
We'd jump the life to come. But in these cases
We still have judgment here; that we but teach
Bloody instructions, which, being taught, return
To plague the inventor: this even-handed justice
Commends the ingredients of our poison'd chalice
To our own lips.
He's here in double trust;
First, as I am his kinsman and his subject,
Strong both against the deed; then, as his host,
Who should against his murderer shut the door,
Not bear the knife myself.
Besides, this Duncan
Hath borne his faculties so meek, hath been
So clear in his great office, that his virtues
Will plead like angels, trumpet-tongued, against
The deep damnation of his taking-off.
I have no spur
To prick the sides of my intent, but only
Vaulting ambition, which o'erleaps itself
And falls on the other.

Reader Notes

This passage is unusually useful for logic because Macbeth almost lays out an argument against murder. He considers consequences, reciprocal violence, justice, loyalty, hospitality, Duncan's virtues, and his own motive. The passage also separates *motive* from *proof*. Macbeth may want the crown, and ambition may push him toward action, but wanting something does not prove that it is right, necessary, or unavoidable.

Reading task: Track the reasons Macbeth gives against the murder. Then notice the final turn: what does he say is actually pushing him forward?

How to Use These Passages on the Worksheet

The worksheet will not ask you to summarize the plot. It will ask you to apply Week 1 logic to Macbeth's reasoning. When answering, quote briefly if useful, but do not fill the box with long quotation. Your job is to name the logical structure: claim, reason, hidden assumption, and follow-test.

Strong college-level answers should do three things:

- separate Shakespeare's dramatic language from the logical movement of the argument;
- avoid treating prophecy, fear, ambition, or confidence as proof by themselves;
- explain the hidden assumption rather than merely naming a theme.